to mere hedonism (not unlike how it's popularly presented in the US today). Crooks grew rich and powerful by posing as Tantric teachers and fooling the superstitious. According to Desai, the moderate Tantric sects of Vaishnava Siddhanta and Shaiva Siddhanta 'spread Tantric practices among the aristocracy and the royal class who were responsible for the building of temples' in Khajuraho. Some Tantrics became advisers to kings and were 'given the highest positions in the temple-organization in many places of India'. In Khajuraho's temple sculptures, Desai adds, the 'completely shaven or bearded and long-haired ascetics' appearing often in orgiastic groups with royal personages 'are, without doubt, Tantrikas'.[48]



Figure 7. Vishwanath Temple panel

In other words, Tantra differed a lot from other dominant streams of religious thought in India. It was the pervasive presence of this substrate in both popular and elite cultures that fertilized the soil for the creation of erotic temple art in Khajuraho and other parts of India.

Fusing Erotic with the Religious